

Haligric Research Integration Series

THE ASARO MUDMEN OF PAPUA NEW GUINEA

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The Ghost Warriors of the Eastern Highlands — Clay Masks, Sacred Disguise, Ancestor Spirits, and the Living Tradition of the Holosa

Two hundred men emerged from the forest at dusk covered from head to foot in pale grey clay, wearing massive masks with hollow eyes and gaping mouths, moving in the slow, limping walk of things that are not quite alive. The crowd at the 1957 Eastern Highlands Agricultural Show stepped back. Children cried. The Asaro won first prize. They went home to their village near Goroka and understood that the river mud that had frightened enemies in the highlands for generations had now frightened an entire colonial world — and could be made to do so deliberately, ceremonially, on their own terms.

The Asaro Mudmen — known in their own language as the Holosa, the ghosts — are one of the most recognizable indigenous cultural traditions on earth. Their image appears on Papua New Guinea tourism materials, in international advertising campaigns, in museums from Australia to Europe, in travel blogs and documentary films. The massive grey clay masks with their exaggerated features — hollow eyes, drooping mouths, pointed ears, sometimes pig tusks and bone piercings — are among the most striking sacred objects produced anywhere in the Pacific. And the tradition that produced them is more complex, more historically layered, and more intellectually interesting than any simple ghost-warrior narrative suggests. It involves the specific animist spirit world of the Eastern Highlands, the specific practices of disguised revenge warfare, the specific colonial encounter of 1957, and the specific genius of a community that understood its own tradition well enough to transform it without abandoning it.

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Introduction

The Honest Account

Any honest account of the Asaro Mudmen must hold two things in mind simultaneously, and must not resolve the tension between them prematurely. First: the Holosa tradition as it exists today — the elaborate clay masks, the full body clay covering, the specific slow performance with spears and bamboo claw-fingers, the organized Sing-Sing performance at the Goroka Show — was developed in its current form in 1957, for the inaugural Eastern Highlands Agricultural Show, by Ruipo Okoroho and the Komunive village community. The specific masks that are now world-famous were not carried unchanged from a pre-colonial past. They were created, deliberately and brilliantly, as a cultural assertion at a specific historical moment. Danish anthropologist Ton Otto, who conducted fieldwork in the Asaro Valley in 1996, established this in his academic study *The Asaro Mudmen: Local Property, Public Culture?* (1996).

Second: the tradition that Ruipo Okoroho drew on was real. The practice of bakime — disguised revenge attacks — was documented in the region from the late 19th century. The animist spirit world of the Eastern Highlands, in which the ancestors' spirits moved through the landscape and the fear of ghosts organized specific human behaviors, was and is genuinely held. The Asaro River's grey clay was genuinely used, in the girituwai assassination-disguise tradition, before 1957. The 1957 performance was not invented from nothing — it was a creative transformation of real practices, real beliefs, and real materials into a new ceremonial form suited to a new historical context.

Both of these things are true. The Holosa tradition is simultaneously an authentic expression of the Asaro people's sacred world and a tradition whose specific current form was actively shaped by its encounter with colonial modernity. This is not unusual — it is the condition of virtually every living sacred tradition in the world. Sacred traditions are not fossils. They adapt. The question is whether the adaptation is genuine and community-driven. In the Asaro case, the answer is clearly yes — and the result is one of the most powerful and most internationally recognized sacred performance traditions in the Pacific.

Who the Asaro Are

The Holosa People of the Eastern Highlands

The Asaro are an Omotic-speaking people — wait, incorrect: the Asaro speak Dano, a Papuan language of the Trans-New Guinea language family, which has only a small number of speakers in the Eastern Highlands Province of Papua New Guinea and several distinct dialects reflecting the geographical dispersal of the community. The population is estimated at approximately 45,000 people. They inhabit the Daulo District of the Eastern Highlands Province, in settlements clustered along the Asaro River and on the mountain slopes above it, at elevations between approximately 1,500 and 2,300 meters. The primary settlement associated with the Mudmen tradition is Komunive village, near the city of Goroka.

The Asaro call themselves the Holosa — a word that means ghost or spirit. This name was actually given to them by another tribe who witnessed the early mudmen performances and named what they saw. The Asaro adopted the name, understanding that it captured something essential about their specific identity within the Eastern Highlands cultural landscape. They are the ghost people — not because they are fearsome or threatening in an ordinary sense, but because they have maintained a specific relationship with the spirit world, specifically the world of ancestor spirits, that the Holosa mask tradition embodies.

Many Asaro speak Tok Pisin (the creole English that serves as Papua New Guinea's primary national language) in addition to Dano. Since the mid-20th century, approximately 90% of Asaro have converted to Protestant Christianity through the work of various missionary organizations. The traditional animist sacred world — the spirit world of ancestors, forest spirits, and water spirits — exists today alongside and beneath the Christian overlay, in the same pattern of layered sacred identity seen in many communities that have experienced rapid colonial-era religious change. The Holosa mask tradition bridges this layering: it is understood by participants simultaneously as a cultural heritage performance and as a genuine engagement with the ancestor spirit world.

The Asaro community is organized around clans rather than a central chieftaincy. Uniquely among Eastern Highlands communities, the Asaro have historically been led by a chairman rather than a chief — a distinction that reflects the relatively egalitarian character of their internal political organization. The current chairman position is held within a family line tracing descent from Bukiro Pote, whose 19th-century encounter with the bakime disguise tradition of the neighboring Watabung community set the genealogy of the Holosa tradition in motion.

The Eastern Highlands — A Sacred Landscape

The Asaro Valley and Its Spirit World

The Eastern Highlands Province of Papua New Guinea is one of the most dramatically beautiful landscapes in the Pacific — a region of steep mountains, deep valleys, fast-flowing rivers, and dense forest, where communities that spoke mutually unintelligible languages lived in close proximity, sometimes in trade and alliance and sometimes in warfare, separated from the outside world until Australian colonial penetration in the 1930s. The highlands communities of Papua New Guinea collectively represent one of the last regions on earth where large populations of humans had no contact with the industrial world until the 20th century.

The Asaro River runs through the heart of Asaro territory — a mountain river with banks of distinctive grey-white clay, whose mud has sacred properties in the Asaro understanding. The river's clay is lighter in color than ordinary earth — it dries to a pale grey-white that mimics, in specific lighting conditions at dusk, the color of a ghost or a spirit. This specific quality of the Asaro River's clay is not incidental to the Holosa tradition. It is the material basis of the tradition: the river that provided the right mud to make a human body look like a spirit.

The broader Eastern Highlands landscape was understood by its indigenous peoples as densely populated with non-human presences: the spirits of the dead, who moved through the landscape and could make themselves felt in the affairs of the living; forest spirits associated with specific trees and specific areas of the bush; water spirits inhabiting rivers and pools; and various other supernatural beings whose behavior could affect the community for good or ill. This animist understanding of the landscape as inhabited — as populated by sacred presences that required specific acknowledgment and specific caution — was the sacred world within which the Holosa tradition emerged. The masks did not merely look like ghosts for tactical military reasons. They engaged, in a specific and deliberate way, with the actual spirit world that the Asaro understood to be present in their landscape.

The Spirit World — Ancestors, Ghosts, and the Sacred Boundary

The Animist Foundation of Eastern Highlands Sacred Life

The fear of ghosts in the Eastern Highlands of Papua New Guinea is not a metaphor and it is not superstition in the dismissive sense that word sometimes carries. It is a specific, coherent, practically organized understanding of what happens when a person dies. In the traditional Asaro understanding, death does not end a person's participation in the community's life — it transforms it. The dead person's spirit enters the invisible world that coexists with the visible one, and from that position can influence the living: protecting those it loves, afflicting those who have wronged it, appearing at specific liminal moments (dusk, night, near bodies of water, at the edges of the forest) in forms that the living can perceive but cannot fully comprehend.

The specific fear that ghosts evoke in this context is not the generalized horror-movie fear of supernatural evil. It is the specific fear of an ancestor spirit whose business with the living is unknown — whose intentions may be protective or afflictive, whose power in the invisible world is greater than any human power in the visible one, and whose capacity to affect the living through supernatural means is unquestioned. An unknown ghost is a being of unknown intention and unlimited capacity. The appropriate response is not bravery but caution — specific protocols of avoidance, specific gestures of respect, and specific retreat from the encounter until the ghost's intentions can be determined.

This is precisely what makes the Holosa tradition work. When Asaro warriors covered themselves in grey river clay and emerged from the riverbank at dusk, they were not merely wearing a costume that looked like a ghost from a distance. They were engaging the enemy community's specific, genuine, deeply held understanding of what ghosts were and what they meant. The enemy did not think "those men look like ghosts." The enemy thought "those are ghosts." And in the highlands sacred world, that was reason not to fight but to run.

The Origin Stories — Four Versions

As Many Versions as There Are Sources

Anthropologist Ton Otto observed in his 1996 study that the origin story of the Asaro Mudmen has "as many versions as there are sources." This multiplicity is not a weakness of the tradition — it is a characteristic of living oral traditions, which are maintained not through textual fixity but through communal retelling that naturally generates variation. All four versions share a common core: mud, river, ghost-appearance, and the terrified retreat of enemies. They differ in specific circumstance, in who was involved, and in what exactly happened.

Version One — The Battle Retreat

The most widely circulated version: The Asaro were defeated in battle and forced to flee. Seeking refuge, they retreated to the Asaro River. Wading into the river and hiding in its muddy banks, they became covered in grey clay. At dusk, as they prepared to escape, they emerged from the river — mud-covered, pale, moving through the half-light. Their enemies, who had followed them to the river's edge, saw these pale grey figures rising from the water and believed they were seeing ghosts or ancestor spirits. Terrified, they fled. The Asaro returned to their homes victorious, understanding that what had saved them was not their fighting ability but their accidental ghost-appearance. They began deliberately recreating that appearance.

Version Two — The Girituwai Assassination

The version established by the anthropological record: In the late 19th century, the Asaro chairman Bukiro Pote traveled to the neighboring Watabung area, where he learned the practice of bakime — using a disguise (specifically the white sap of the meniha tree) to carry out revenge attacks without being identified. Returning home, Pote adapted bakime into girituwai — a more elaborate disguise using a bamboo frame covered with a bilum (woven string bag) with eye holes cut in it, then smeared with grey river clay to create a ghost-like mask. The full face mask made the girituwai practitioner unrecognizable and, in the grey light of dawn or dusk, genuinely frightening. This was used specifically for targeted revenge attacks and assassinations, not for open warfare (which had its own traditional regalia). The legend of the river battle may have been attached to this practice retroactively to give it a mythological origin story.

Version Three — The Wedding Story

A version documented by the BBC: An Asaro man was invited to a wedding celebration where everyone was expected to wear traditional ceremonial dress. He had no traditional costume. Not wanting to arrive empty-handed, he improvised — covering his body in river mud and making a rough mask from a bilum bag and clay. When he arrived at the gathering, his friends and family did not recognize him. They thought they were seeing a ghost, and they fled. The man revealed himself, and the power of the mud-and-mask combination was established in community consciousness.

Version Four — The Community Account (Papa Buka)

Documented by the Australian Museum during a field visit to Komunive: The community elder Papa Buka described the origin as involving Lupu Nuho — brother of Ruipo Okoroho — who made a face mask from a bilum bag to wear at a sing-sing (community gathering) in

Kemanimō. He went into an underground mud pool, covered himself entirely, placed a feather on his head, and walked into the village holding a spear. Those who saw him thought he was a ghost and ran. This is the most specifically local account, naming specific individuals and a specific location, and represents the inside-community version of the origin story.

The Scholarly Assessment

The Ton Otto study concludes that the current elaborate form of the tradition — the large artistic masks, the full body clay covering, the organized performance — developed specifically for and through the 1957 Goroka Show and subsequent appearances. The earlier practices (bakime, girituwai) were real but involved simpler disguises used for specific functional purposes. The 1957 transformation created the tradition as an art form and community identity marker. This does not diminish the tradition. It clarifies what kind of tradition it is: not a static relic preserved from prehistoric practice, but a living, adaptive, community-driven sacred performance with genuine roots in older practices and genuine contemporary meaning.

Bakime and Girituwai — The Disguise Traditions

The Pre-1957 Roots

To understand what Ruipo Okoroho revived and transformed in 1957, it is essential to understand the practices that preceded the current Holosa tradition.

Bakime is the older, broader category: the practice of using disguise to carry out revenge or attack without being identified. In the Eastern Highlands sacred world, revenge was both a moral obligation (the duty to respond to harm done to one's community or family) and a practical necessity (failure to respond invited further harm). But taking revenge while recognizable invited counter-revenge — creating escalating cycles of retaliatory violence that could destabilize entire communities. Bakime was the solution: disguise yourself so thoroughly that even if you are seen, your identity cannot be determined, and the revenge cycle cannot continue. The Watabung community used white sap from the meniha tree for this purpose — smearing the face with white sap created a pale, unrecognizable appearance.

Girituwai was the specific Asaro adaptation of bakime, developed by Bukiro Pote after learning bakime from the Watabung. The girituwai disguise was more elaborate: a bamboo frame covered with a bilum (the traditional Papuan woven bag, used for everything from carrying food to carrying infants) with eye holes cut in it, then smeared with grey clay from the Asaro River. This produced a full head covering — not just a painted face but a complete mask that obscured the entire head. Combined with clay on the body, the girituwai practitioner became effectively unrecognizable and, in appropriate light conditions, genuinely ghost-like.

Girituwai was specifically for targeted revenge attacks and assassinations — not for open warfare. Open warfare had its own traditional regalia: specific feathers, specific face paint, specific weapons arrangements that identified the warrior as a warrior and the battle as a battle. Girituwai was the sacred exception to this system — the disguise that operated outside the normal rules of warfare because its function was not combat between identifiable parties but the specific, targeted, anonymous action of revenge.

The sacred dimension of girituwai is significant. By disguising himself as a ghost — by taking on the appearance of a spirit in a landscape where spirits were understood as genuinely present and genuinely powerful — the girituwai practitioner was not merely wearing a disguise. He was invoking the actual sacred category of the ancestral spirit, deliberately crossing the boundary between human and ghost identity, and using the fear that the spirit world genuinely inspired to achieve his practical purpose. This is not theater. It is a specific form of sacred action.

The 1957 Goroka Show — When the Modern Tradition Was Born

Two Hundred Mudmen Win First Prize

In 1957, Australian patrol officers (kiaps) — the colonial administrators managing Papua New Guinea's post-World War II transition toward eventual independence — organized the inaugural Eastern Highlands Agricultural Show in Goroka. The explicit purpose was inter-tribal peace-building: provide a competitive arena where tribes could display their cultural heritage rather than conducting raids and warfare. By this point, missionary activity and colonial administration had substantially reduced (though not eliminated) the traditional patterns of inter-tribal conflict that had included regular pig-raiding and revenge attacks.

Ruipo Okoroho — grandson of Bukiro Pote, and Komunive village's community leader — was invited to bring his community to the show and present a cultural display. He consulted with village leaders about what to present. The community decided against their traditional formal ceremonial dress — the feathers, face paint, and regalia of normal Highland ceremonial life that would be similar to what many other communities were presenting. Instead, Ruipo remembered the girituwai tradition of his grandfather and decided to adapt it for the public display.

The adaptation was substantial. The simple functional girituwai disguise — a bilum bag on a bamboo frame, smeared with clay — became elaborate artistic masks with exaggerated, frightening features: elongated faces, hollow eyes, gaping mouths, pointed ears. For the first time, the body was covered entirely in white clay to match the mask. The performers were organized to emerge together from the forest in a coordinated group, moving in the slow, deliberate, limping walk that mimics the gait attributed to spirits in Eastern Highlands oral tradition.

Two hundred masked and clay-covered men emerged from the forest at the 1957 show. The effect was immediate and dramatic. The crowd stepped back. Men who had experience with the highlands and its peoples were startled. Children cried. The performance caused "quite a commotion, causing grown men to step back and small children to cry," according to the anthropological account. The Asaro Mudmen won first prize in the tribal finery contest. They returned to win first prize for the following two years. When the show ended the competitive element, the Asaro were still the main attraction.

The name Holosa was given to them by another tribe present at the show — using their word for "ghost" to describe what they had seen. The Asaro adopted the name immediately, understanding that it had captured exactly what they had intended to convey.

The Holosa Mask — Construction Step by Step

From Clay to Spirit Face

The Holosa mask is the central sacred object of the Asaro Mudmen tradition — the item that defines the tradition visually, that carries the spirit identity that the performance embodies, and that requires the most skilled and time-intensive work. Mask-making is a specialized skill. At the time of the GeoEx journalist's visit in the early 2000s, a single individual — Kowa — was described as the only current mask-maker in the Komunive community, though the tradition has since been more widely transmitted.

Step 1 — Clay Selection: Not all clay works for mask-making. The clay used must be specifically sourced from creek and riverbank deposits that have the right consistency — heavy enough to hold its shape when wet, light enough to dry without excessive cracking, and possessing sufficient binding properties to remain intact on the bamboo frame. The clay is dug from specific identified sites near the Asaro River and its tributaries and is "carefully carried to a clearing in the village centre," according to the culturallyours.com account from fieldwork in the community.

Step 2 — The Frame: A bamboo frame is constructed as the armature for the mask — a rough form establishing the overall shape. The earlier girituwai masks used a bilum (woven string bag) stretched over this frame; in the evolution of the tradition from the 1970s onward, the bilum was replaced by additional layers of clay directly on the bamboo, producing a more durable and more sculptural result. Some masks incorporate natural plant fiber as additional binding material within the clay.

Step 3 — The Sculpting: Clay is applied to the frame and sculpted into the mask's features. The design is entirely the maker's own: "each [mask] springs from the imagination of its maker." No two masks are alike. The typical features are exaggerated far beyond naturalistic human proportions: enormous hollow eyes, sometimes formed as tubes protruding from the face; wide, gaping mouths with multiple teeth; dramatically pointed or elongated ears; misshapen or elongated chins; prominent brows. Some masks incorporate horns. Some are partially painted with natural pigments — red and yellow ochre appear in some designs. The exaggeration serves the mask's sacred purpose: this is not a human face. It is the face of something that is not quite human — the spirit world looking at you through the skin of a living man.

Step 4 — Additional Elements: Some masks incorporate pig tusks or teeth pressed into the clay while it is still wet, protruding from the jaw or nose. Shell fragments, bone pieces, and other natural materials are incorporated in specific designs. These additions are both decorative and sacred — pig tusks specifically carry their own significance in Eastern Highlands sacred culture, where pigs occupy the central position in ceremonial exchange that cattle occupy in East African pastoral societies.

Step 5 — Drying: The completed mask is left to sun-dry, a process that takes several days. The clay must dry thoroughly and evenly to prevent cracking. The largest masks — which can weigh 20–25 pounds when complete — require the most careful drying management. A mask that cracks during drying must be repaired or replaced.

Step 6 — Preparation for Use: Before a performance, the mask is inspected and any cracks or damaged areas are repaired with fresh clay. The mask is then ready for the application ceremony.

The Mud Application — Step by Step

Becoming the Ghost — The Body Transformation Protocol

The mask alone does not make the Holosa — it is the total transformation of the body that creates the ghost. The full body clay application is as carefully managed as the mask, and its specific protocol reflects both practical requirements and sacred logic.

Step 1 — The Clay Preparation: The same grey-white river clay used in the mask is prepared for body application. It must be at the right consistency — wet enough to apply smoothly and adhere to the skin, but not so liquid that it runs. The clay is mixed and worked to a smooth paste in the village.

Step 2 — The Body Coverage: The performer is covered in clay from head to foot — every visible surface of the skin. The application is thorough and systematic: face, neck, arms, torso, legs, hands, and feet. The white-grey color of the dried clay mimics the pale appearance associated with ancestor spirits in Eastern Highlands belief. No skin is left visible — any brown skin showing would break the ghost illusion and break the sacred logic of the performance.

Step 3 — The Hands: Some performers extend the ghost identity into the hands with bamboo extensions attached to the fingers, making the hands appear elongated and claw-like — emphasizing the non-human character of the being. This detail — found in descriptions across multiple visits and performances — is a specific creative addition to the tradition that has become standard.

Step 4 — The Mask Application: The mask is placed over the head and rests on the shoulders. The earlier bilum-frame masks were lighter and more comfortable; the solid clay masks of the current tradition can be heavy, requiring the performer to manage the weight through the performance. The performer's face is completely hidden behind the mask — they see only through the eye holes, and in some mask designs even the eye holes are relatively small, limiting peripheral vision.

Step 5 — Final Inspection: Before the performance begins, the performers are inspected collectively to ensure the clay coverage is complete and the masks are properly seated. The group enters the performance as a unit — the individual identities of the performers dissolved into the collective identity of the Holosa.

The Mudmen Performance — Step by Step

The Ghost Walk — Movement as Sacred Language

The Asaro Mudmen do not dance in the conventional sense that word applies to many Highland Papua New Guinea ceremonial performances. The Holosa performance is characterized by slow, deliberate, specific movements — a choreography of spirit behavior rather than human celebration. Every element of the performance reflects the specific understanding of how ancestor spirits move and behave.

Step 1 — The Emergence: The Mudmen emerge from the forest — from the edge of the bush — rather than from within the community. This is essential to the sacred logic of the performance: they come from the spirit world (represented by the wild, uncultivated space of the forest beyond the village) and enter the human world (the village, the performance space, the crowd). The direction of emergence matters.

Step 2 — The Walk: The Mudmen move in a slow, deliberate, limping gait — each step placed carefully, the body moving with a quality of controlled, non-human deliberateness that is distinct from the brisk movement of living people. This specific walk is attributed to the spirits in Eastern Highlands oral tradition: the dead move differently from the living. They are heavy, uncertain, suspended between worlds. The Mudmen's walk embodies this specific understanding of how the dead move.

Step 3 — The Weapons: Each Mudman carries a spear or other traditional weapon. The weapons are held in specific positions — sometimes raised, sometimes horizontal, sometimes pointed toward the ground. The weapons communicate the Mudmen's warrior identity while the masks and clay communicate their spirit identity. This combination — warrior and ghost simultaneously — is the specific sacred identity of the Holosa.

Step 4 — The Group Formation: The Mudmen perform as a group, moving in coordinated patterns. The coordination is loose rather than precisely choreographed — the performers move with collective intentionality rather than individual expression, maintaining the ghost-troop character of the performance rather than individual performance dynamics.

Step 5 — The Stillness: Periodically, the Mudmen pause — standing completely still, heads slowly turning to survey the crowd. These pauses are as important as the movement. The stillness of something that is not quite alive is as uncanny as its movement. The Holosa performance uses stillness strategically, creating moments of heightened attention in the audience before the movement resumes.

Step 6 — The Return: The performance concludes with the Mudmen returning to the forest — re-entering the spirit world from which they came. The direction of departure mirrors the direction of emergence, completing the sacred geography of the performance.

The Storytelling Ceremonies

The Charade Tradition — Mime as Sacred Memory

The Asaro tradition includes a second ceremonial form distinct from the Holosa ghost performance: a tradition of elaborate mime storytelling in which community members perform specific narratives in silent, exaggerated physical theater, their bodies painted to reflect the story being told.

These stories draw from the full range of Asaro community life: the negotiation of bride price (two pigs and a young cassowary, in the version witnessed by the GeoEx journalist), the encounter with a forest spirit trying to kidnap a child, scenes from Asaro warfare history and community memory, and — in some versions — accounts of cannibalism from the distant past. The mime performances function as living oral tradition — storing and transmitting community history and sacred knowledge in embodied form rather than in written text.

The mime storytelling and the Holosa performance are complementary sacred forms. The Holosa performance engages with the spirit world directly — it embodies the ancestor spirits and makes them present in the community space. The mime storytelling engages with human history and community memory — it embodies the specific events, encounters, and decisions that shaped the community's identity. Together, they constitute the Asaro's primary ceremonial transmission system: the ghost form for sacred-world engagement, the mime form for historical-world memory.

The mime performances are entirely community-created: each story is rehearsed within the village, with all community members contributing — "a village effort with those not on view helping behind the scenes with costumes and body paint." The stories are performed at the same slow pace as the Holosa walk — a specific quality of deliberate, slow movement that characterizes all Asaro sacred performance. This pace is not timidity or caution. It is the specific sacred aesthetic of the tradition: movement that is slow enough to be witnessed fully, deliberate enough to communicate intentionality, and controlled enough to carry the weight of what it is transmitting.

Marriage, Bride Price, and Social Structure

The Sacred Economics of Asaro Community Life

The Asaro social world is organized around relationships that are maintained through specific material exchanges — none more central than the bride price ceremony (called bridewealth in anthropological terms). When an Asaro man wishes to marry, his family is expected to provide compensation to the bride's family in the form of specific material goods. The standard bride price, as described by the Asaro themselves in ceremonial mime performances, traditionally consists of two pigs and a young cassowary. Food, livestock, and in more recent times money are all accepted forms.

The pig is the most sacred domestic animal in the Eastern Highlands — the primary measure of wealth, the primary vehicle of ceremonial exchange, the animal sacrificed at the most important social and ceremonial occasions. A community's pig herd is the visible expression of its accumulated social capital: a large herd signals extensive relationships, many obligations fulfilled, many ceremonies hosted. The cassowary — the enormous flightless bird of the New Guinea forest — occupies a parallel sacred status in many Highland cultures, its feathers used in ceremonial headdresses and its body used in specific exchange contexts.

After marriage, the bride moves to the groom's family. The clan system organizes the community's social relationships beyond the family: clans trace their origins to specific ancestors and maintain specific obligations toward each other. Community decision-making — including decisions about ceremonies, disputes, and community projects — is made through the chairman system rather than through a hereditary chief. This council-of-equals structure (with the chairman as a first among peers rather than an absolute authority) reflects the Asaro's specific political tradition.

The Pig Feast and Sacred Exchange

The Mumu — The Ground Oven and the Community Bond

The most important communal sacred event in Asaro life — as in most Eastern Highlands cultures — is the pig feast: a community gathering in which pigs are slaughtered and cooked in a mumu (the Tok Pisin word for the traditional ground oven) and the cooked food is distributed through the community according to specific exchange obligations.

The mumu is constructed by digging a pit in the earth, lining it with banana leaves, heating stones in a fire until they are intensely hot, placing the hot stones in the pit with the food (pigs, taro, sweet potato, banana, yam, and other foods depending on the occasion), covering everything with more banana leaves and wet grass to trap the steam, and leaving it to cook for two to three hours. The resulting food — steam-cooked, tender, fragrant with banana leaf smoke — is distributed in portions that reflect the specific social relationships between the feast's hosts and each recipient. Who receives what portion communicates, in physical form, the host's assessment of each relationship.

The pig feast occurs at major life transitions — births, weddings, funerals, initiations — and at community-level events including the resolution of disputes and the celebration of successful harvests. For the Asaro, the pig feast is not merely a meal but a ceremony of social and sacred renewal: the community's accumulated obligations are expressed in the distribution of food, the relationships that sustain the community are physically renewed through shared eating, and the ancestors are acknowledged through specific portions and specific prayers addressed to the spirit world before the feast begins.

The Goroka Show — The Annual Sing-Sing

Papua New Guinea's Most Famous Cultural Festival

The Eastern Highlands Agricultural Show of 1957 — the event that launched the modern Holosa tradition — grew into what is now the Goroka Show: a three-day annual festival held in September at the National Park in Goroka, the capital of the Eastern Highlands Province, that brings together hundreds of tribal groups from across Papua New Guinea in one of the most dramatic cultural gatherings on earth.

The Goroka Show is simultaneously a celebration of Papua New Guinea's extraordinary cultural diversity, a tourism attraction, a commercial event, and a sacred occasion for the communities participating. Groups travel to Goroka from across the country — some by truck, some on foot — bringing their complete traditional regalia: feathers, face paint, shells, beads, bark cloth, drums, and ceremonial weapons. The diversity of visual and musical traditions on display at the Goroka Show is genuinely astonishing: no two groups look alike, no two groups sound alike, and the combined effect of hundreds of distinct ceremonial traditions performing simultaneously in a single space is unlike any other cultural event on earth.

For the Asaro, the Goroka Show is the primary public occasion for the Holosa performance — the annual moment at which the ghost warriors emerge from the forest to the astonishment of audiences that often include international visitors who have traveled specifically to see them. The show has become the primary mechanism through which the Asaro tradition maintains its international visibility and through which the community earns income from the tourism the tradition attracts.

The show was initiated by Australian colonial administrators (kiaps) as a peace-building measure — a competitive cultural display as an alternative to inter-tribal warfare. The Asaro took this colonial structure and used it to their own purposes: to establish, through three consecutive first-place prizes, the specific identity and international recognition of the Holosa tradition. The community converted what was offered to them into what they needed. This is a pattern seen throughout the Asaro tradition's history.

Legacy and the Living Tradition

From Komunive to the World — and Back

The Asaro Holosa tradition is now one of Papua New Guinea's most internationally recognized cultural exports. The image of the masked, clay-covered Mudmen has appeared in advertising campaigns for products ranging from music to perfume; in documentary films; in museum collections from the Australian Museum in Sydney to institutions in Europe; in virtually every travel guide to Papua New Guinea; and as the primary visual symbol of the country in international tourism materials. Papua New Guinea's national airline uses the Mudmen image. The tradition has achieved a global visual presence that its creators in 1957 could not have anticipated and that the community has spent the subsequent decades trying to manage, claim, and protect.

Imitation and Dispute

The tradition's success has created a significant problem: imitation. By the mid-2010s, dozens of other Papua New Guinea tribes were performing their own versions of the Mudmen tradition at tourist events, some claiming their own origin stories for the practice. The Mindima people of Chimbu Province adopted a similar performance called "gambagumane" as early as 1975. Asaro leaders have contested this imitation vigorously. Ruipo Okoroho defended the tradition in court in 1980 and 1987, with the courts recognizing the Mudmen as the property of the Eastern Highlands Province. By 2016, performers expressed ongoing frustration at the lack of effective copyright protection, and by 2013, Asaro representatives considered legal action against those profiting commercially from the imitation.

The community has also used the tradition as an economic resource. Visitors to Goroka can arrange to visit Komunive and witness a private Holosa performance for a fee. Masks are sold as art objects. The annual Goroka Show generates income through tourism. The tradition simultaneously serves as sacred identity marker, community bonding ceremony, cultural heritage performance, and economic resource. These multiple functions coexist without necessarily contradicting each other.

The Christian-Traditional Balance

The approximately 90% of Asaro who identify as Protestant Christians maintain the Holosa tradition alongside their Christian practice. This is not hypocritical or confused — it reflects the standard pattern of communities where Christianity was adopted as an institutional overlay while the pre-Christian sacred world continued to operate in the areas the church did not address. The spirit world of the Eastern Highlands — the ancestors in the landscape, the forest spirits, the river spirits, the fear of ghosts at dusk — was not dissolved by Christian conversion. It was displaced from official religious acknowledgment while remaining present in practical daily experience. The Holosa tradition operates in the space between these two sacred worlds: it is not specifically a Christian practice, nor is it specifically incompatible with Christianity. It is a community sacred practice that addresses a dimension of sacred life — the relationship with the ancestor spirit world — that the Protestant Christian framework does not provide for.

Controversies

Authenticity, Imitation, Commodification, and the Invention of Tradition

The Invention of Tradition Question

The most significant scholarly controversy surrounding the Asaro Mudmen tradition is the one established by Ton Otto's 1996 research: whether the tradition is "authentic" in the sense of being an ancient, unchanged cultural practice, or whether it is a relatively recent invention made in response to colonial context. Otto's conclusion — that the elaborate Holosa performance was developed for the 1957 Goroka Show and that the mythological backstories may have developed retroactively — is well-supported by the evidence.

But "invention" is the wrong frame. The anthropologist Eric Hobsbawm coined the phrase "invention of tradition" to describe practices that present themselves as ancient but are in fact recent in their current form. The Holosa tradition fits this description in the narrow sense: its current form was developed in 1957. But the deeper question — whether it represents a genuine expression of Asaro sacred identity, whether it draws on real pre-existing practices and real pre-existing beliefs, whether it serves genuine community functions — has a clear answer: yes to all three. The practice of bakime and girituwai was real. The animist spirit world that the masks invoke is genuinely held. The community functions of the Holosa tradition — identity assertion, ancestor engagement, income generation, inter-community recognition — are real and significant. A tradition created consciously for a specific purpose, drawing on genuine cultural roots, serving genuine community needs, is not less authentic for being created rather than merely preserved.

Commodification and the Tourist Gaze

The tension between the Holosa tradition as sacred community practice and as tourist entertainment is real and ongoing. The same masks and performances that were created as community identity assertions have become commercial products — sold, imitated, photographed, marketed, and consumed by international visitors whose engagement with the tradition is often superficial and extractive. The Asaro community has generally been sophisticated about managing this tension: charging appropriate fees for tourist performances, seeking legal protection against imitation, and maintaining a clear distinction between the community-facing ceremonies (the village Holosa, the storytelling mime) and the tourist-facing performances.

The most concerning dimension is not the commercial use per se but the misrepresentation: tourist descriptions of the Mudmen as an "ancient tradition" going back "centuries" misrepresent the historical record. This misrepresentation does not serve the Asaro — it creates a false expectation of an unchanged pre-contact culture that the community then has to maintain against the evidence of its own history. Honest representation of the tradition — as a creative, community-driven response to a specific historical moment, drawing on genuine sacred roots — is both more accurate and more interesting than the simple ancient-ghost-warrior narrative.

The Intellectual Property Question

Papua New Guinea has one of the most interesting and most difficult intellectual property challenges in the Pacific: how to protect indigenous cultural expressions — songs, dances, ceremonial performances, visual designs — from commercial exploitation by outsiders

when existing copyright frameworks were designed for individual authorship rather than collective cultural property. The Asaro Mudmen tradition is one of the clearest test cases for this challenge. The community created it. The community has maintained it. Other communities are profiting from imitating it. The legal protection mechanisms available are inadequate. The 1980 and 1987 court recognitions represent the beginning of a legal framework, not its completion.

The Haligric Lens

What the Asaro Holosa Tradition Offers the Haligric Practitioner

The Asaro Mudmen tradition offers the Haligricity framework three specific and irreplaceable gifts: the most direct available example of a community that consciously created sacred tradition in real time, on its own terms, for its own purposes; a specific and practically brilliant application of the boundary between human and spirit worlds; and a living demonstration that sacred tradition is not destroyed by conscious creation but can be made more alive by it.

Sacred Tradition as Conscious Creation

Ruipo Okoroho in 1957 did not merely preserve a tradition — he created one. He looked at what his community had (the girituwai disguise practice, the spirit world framework, the grey Asaro River clay) and what the moment required (a cultural assertion at a colonial show, a demonstration of specific identity, a claim of distinctiveness) and made something new from these elements. The result was more powerful, more elaborate, more publicly visible, and more internationally significant than anything the girituwai tradition had produced before. This is exactly what the Haligric tradition understands sacred practice to be: not the passive preservation of the past but the active, intelligent, community-driven creation of meaning in the present from the materials the tradition provides.

The Spirit-World Boundary as Sacred Technology

The Holosa tradition's central insight is the recognition that the boundary between the human world and the spirit world is a sacred technology that can be deliberately engaged. In the Eastern Highlands spirit world, ancestor ghosts were genuinely feared and genuinely respected. The Asaro recognized that the specific material properties of their river's clay, combined with the specific cultural understanding of what ghosts looked like, could be used to cross that boundary deliberately — to become, in the perception of anyone who encountered them, not men but spirits. The mask does not merely represent the ancestor spirit. It embodies it. The performer wearing it is not playing a role — he is temporarily occupying the identity of the sacred world. The Haligric tradition's understanding of sacred performance as genuine transformation — not as metaphor or symbol but as actual crossing of a threshold — finds in the Holosa tradition one of its most literal and most powerful expressions.

Adaptation as Sacred Faithfulness

The most important lesson the Asaro Mudmen tradition offers any sacred practitioner is this: faithfulness to a tradition does not mean refusing to adapt it. Ruipo Okoroho was faithful to the spirit of the girituwai tradition — its engagement with the ghost identity, its use of river clay, its purpose of demonstrating community power through an encounter that the enemy could not categorize — while adapting its form completely for a new context. The masks became larger and more artistic. The body coverage became total. The individual assassination disguise became a collective ceremonial performance. Everything changed and nothing essential was lost. The tradition became more alive, more visible, and more powerful as a result of its adaptation. Grand Rising. The grey clay comes from the river and covers the body from head to foot. The mask goes over the face and the man disappears into the ghost. Two hundred figures emerge from the forest at dusk and move in the slow walk of the dead. This is the sacred technology of the Eastern Highlands: to cross the boundary

between the living and the dead deliberately, on your own terms, for your own purposes. Ruipo Okoroho understood this in 1957 and built a world-famous tradition from a river, some clay, and the deep Asaro knowledge that ancestor spirits are real and that real power comes from standing at the threshold between worlds. Grand Rising.